

LOGICAL FALLACY CHEAT SHEET

Short Syllable Names • Quick Definitions • Memorable Examples
23 Common Fallacies • Designed for Fast Recall & Critical Thinking Practice

■ **HOW TO MEMORIZE:** Focus on the short rhythmic name first (with syllable count). Read the definition. Then lock in the example. Say the short name out loud — the rhythm and few syllables make it stick! Practice spotting these in conversations, social media, news, and debates.

THE 23 FALLACIES

1. Strawman (2 syllables)

Misrepresenting or exaggerating someone's argument into a weaker, distorted version that's easier to attack.

Example: A says, "We should add more security cameras in the building." B replies, "So you don't trust any of your neighbors and think everyone's a thief?"

2. Ad Hom (2 syllables)

Attacking the person making the argument instead of the argument itself.

Example: "You can't trust her opinion on taxes—she's just a rich kid who never worked a real job."

3. Auth Appeal (3 syllables)

Treating a claim as true simply because an authority or expert said so, without evidence.

Example: "This diet plan is proven to work because a celebrity doctor endorsed it on TV."

4. Either Or (3 syllables)

Presenting only two extreme options when more realistic choices exist (false dilemma).

Example: "You're either with us or against us—there's no middle ground."

5. Slippery Slope (4 syllables)

Claiming a small first step will inevitably lead to extreme, usually disastrous, outcomes without proof.

Example: "If we let kids have phones in school, soon they'll never learn anything and society will collapse."

6. Circle Logic (3 syllables)

Assuming the conclusion in the premise (circular reasoning or begging the question).

Example: "This policy is the best because it's the right thing to do, and we know it's right because it's the best policy."

7. Hasty Gen (3 syllables)

Drawing a broad conclusion from too small or unrepresentative a sample.

Example: "I met two rude people from that city, so everyone there must be rude."

8. Red Herring (3 syllables)

Introducing an irrelevant topic to distract from the real issue.

Example: In a debate about rising crime: "But remember how the mayor fixed the potholes last year?"

9. Feel Appeal (3 syllables)

Manipulating emotions (fear, pity, anger) instead of using logic or evidence.

Example: "If you don't support this bill, you clearly don't care about the children who will suffer."

10. Bandwagon (3 syllables)

Arguing something is true or good simply because many people believe or do it.

Example: "Everyone is investing in this cryptocurrency, so you should get in now before it's too late."

11. Post Hoc (2 syllables)

Assuming that because one event followed another, the first caused the second (false cause).

Example: "I wore my lucky socks and the team won. The socks made them win."

12. Ignor Call (3 syllables)

Claiming something is true because it hasn't been proven false (or vice versa).

Example: "No one has proven that aliens don't visit Earth, so they must be here."

13. You Too (2 syllables)

Dismissing criticism by accusing the critic of hypocrisy (tu quoque).

Example: "You say I should quit smoking, but you used to smoke for years!"

14. No True Scot (3 syllables)

Redefining a category to exclude counterexamples after the fact.

Example: "No true patriot would ever criticize the government like that."

15. Word Shift (2 syllables)

Using a word with different meanings ambiguously within the same argument (equivocation).

Example: "A light meal is healthy. This lamp is light. Therefore, this lamp is healthy."

16. Gene Fault (2 syllables)

Judging an idea or thing based on its origin or source rather than its actual merit.

Example: "That economic idea came from a socialist country, so it has to be wrong."

17. Old Way (2 syllables)

Arguing something is better or correct simply because it's traditional or "always been done."

Example: "We've always held this meeting on Fridays, so we shouldn't change it."

18. Middle Way (3 syllables)

Assuming the compromise position between two extremes is automatically correct or best.

Example: "One side wants \$0 spending, the other wants \$100 million. The fair amount must be \$50 million."

19. Cherry Pick (3 syllables)

Selectively using only evidence that supports your view while ignoring contradictory data.

Example: "This treatment works great—I felt better the day after I started it." (ignoring later results and studies)

20. One Tale (2 syllables)

Using a personal story or single example as proof for a general claim (anecdotal).

Example: "My cousin smoked every day and lived to 92, so smoking can't be that harmful."

21. False Match (2 syllables)

Treating two very different things as equivalent (false equivalence).

Example: "Both candidates made one misleading statement, so they're equally dishonest."

22. Goal Move (2 syllables)

Changing the standards or requirements after the other side has met the original ones (moving the goalposts).

Example: "You need a bachelor's degree for this job." (After the candidate earns one) "Actually, we now require a master's too."

23. Burden Flip (3 syllables)

Demanding the other person disprove your claim instead of providing evidence for it (shifting the burden of proof).

Example: "I believe this supplement cures all diseases. If you disagree, prove it doesn't."

Memorize the short name first → Understand the pattern → Spot it in real life.

Perfect for students, debaters, critical thinkers, teachers, and anyone who values clear reasoning.

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